

FINAL FANTASY XIV TTRPG
STARTER SET



PLAYER BOOK

READ THIS FIRST

FINAL FANTASY XIV

TABLETOP ROLEPLAYING GAME

Hydaelyn—a vibrant planet blessed by the light of the Crystal.

Amid azure seas, encompassing the westernmost of the Three Great Continents, there lies a realm embraced by gods and forged by heroes. Her name...Eorzea.

Eorzean history charts the rise of a succession of great civilizations, each enjoying an age of peace—the Astral Eras. To date, all have proven ephemeral.

In the year 1572 of the Sixth and most recent Astral Era, the northern empire of Garlemald amassed a great army at the heart of Eorzea, seeking dominion over all. Rising in desperate resistance, the forces of the Eorzean Alliance met their would-be conquerors in the field.

Yet even as the battle raged, the lesser moon, Dalamud, was plucked from the heavens through imperial machination.

From its core emerged the elder primal Bahamut, who unleashed his fury upon the realm.

The devastation brought Eorzea to its knees, and the era to its end. Yet every end marks a new beginning.

Five years have come and gone.

The light of life still shines upon Eorzea.

Man labors tirelessly to raise himself from the Calamity's ruin.

The realm is forever changed, a stranger to him once more.

Yet heedless of what lies ahead, he shall press on, spurred by the promise of peace and prosperity.

Amid this period of great change, an adventurer arrives in Eorzea... one whose tale is yet unwritten.

May he ever walk in the light of the Crystal.



INTRODUCTION

The Final Fantasy XIV Tabletop Roleplaying Game is a gateway into the magical world of Final Fantasy XIV through which you and your friends can embark on exciting and memorable adventures. Whereas Final Fantasy XIV Online tells the tale of the Warrior of Light, this game allows you to assume the role of one of Hydaelyn's many unsung adventurers and experience the star's myriad wonders for yourself.

When you play the Final Fantasy XIV TTRPG, one player will act as your gamemaster—the game's arbiter and lead storyteller. The rest of your group will play as adventurers, and together, you will weave your very own tales of adventure.

Keep in mind that this game is not about winning or losing. If you have a good time collaborating with your friends to create an exciting story, everyone wins.

STARTER SET COMPONENTS

This starter set includes the following components, which will provide everything you'll need to start playing the Final Fantasy XIV TTRPG.

- ◆ Final Fantasy XIV TTRPG Player Book
- ◆ Final Fantasy XIV TTRPG Gamemaster Book
- ◆ Dice x16 (6d20 & 10d6)
- ◆ Premade Adventurer Sheets x12
- ◆ Rule Summary & Strategy Guide Sheets x4
- ◆ Encounter Maps x3
- ◆ Markers & Character Token Punchouts x4

LEARNING HOW TO PLAY

The following pages introduce the game's core concepts through a series of vignettes. Each scene is presented as a dialogue between players and their GM, with an accompanying comic to illustrate these ideas.

Once you've read through these scenes, skim through the Player Book to familiarize yourself with the rules. When you're ready, crack open the Gamemaster Book and flip to Chapter 3, which walks you through the steps you'll need to take to prepare for your very first session of the Final Fantasy XIV TTRPG.

Symbols and Formatting in This Book

Bolded Blue Text: Primary and Secondary Attributes

Bolded Red Text: Ability Names

[]: Steps and Timing

Italics: Dialogue and Ability Type

Bold: Enhancements, Enfeeblements, and Traits

: Scenario Text to Read Aloud

: GM Only Scenario Information

: Enemy Invoked Ability

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Before diving in to the game's rules, read through this tutorial to get an idea of how the Final Fantasy XIV TTRPG is played!

SCENE 1: PREPARING FOR THE GAME



GM

If everyone's ready, let's jump right into our first session of the FFXIV TTRPG. I'll be running the game as your gamemaster, or GM. Since I didn't have you pick your adventurers beforehand, we should do that now.



The Starter Set comes with four premade adventurer sheets that we can choose from!



Nice! But, wait, does that mean we're stuck playing as the character pictured at the top of the sheet?



GM

Don't worry, the art is just there to help you imagine what an adventurer with that job might look like. You're free to choose your character's race and name, just like in FFXIV.



So even though the adventurer on the warrior's sheet is a Hyur, I could play as a Roegadyn if I wanted to? Neat.



Is there anything else we need to do to prep our adventurers?



GM

It's not strictly required, but I'd also suggest coming up with some personal details for their profile. Asking yourself why your character became an adventurer and what they do in Eorzea between quests will help bring them to life and give you some ideas for roleplaying.



Hmm... I might need some time to think about it.



Blaze - BLM

Mind if I go first? I play a Miqu'te black mage in FFXIV, so I'd like to do the same here. I'm not great at coming up with names, but...let's go with Blaze. Their curiosity and thirst for knowledge inspired them to become an adventurer so they could unravel the world's many mysteries and go where no Eorzean has gone before.



Warner - WAR

Good stuff! I'll go warrior, then. Hrothgar and Au Ra are pretty cool, but I think I'll stick with Hyur this time. My adventurer's name is Warner, and he's a mercenary. His parents died when he was a baby, so he taught himself how to swing an axe to put bread on the table. He moonlights as an adventurer since there's no shortage of work for them in Eorzea.



Whitley - WHM

It looks as if our party needs a healer and another DPS. Would it be all right if I take the white mage? I'd like to take my time with my character's background, so I'll just pick a name and race now and fill in the details later. Let's see... I'll be a Lalafell named Whitley.



Draken - DRG

Guess that means I'll be our second DPS. He's an Elezen named Draken, and he's the heir to an old Ishgardian house. Following in his family's tradition, he took up the lance and became a dragoon. He takes jobs from the Adventurers' Guild to hone his skills.



GM

Perfect! That gives me an idea of your adventurers' personalities. One last thing before we start playing: tell me how your characters met and formed a party. In the interest of time, why don't we go around the table and have each of you say how your adventurer knows the adventurer of the player to your left?





Let's see here... Blaze needed extra muscle to explore some newly discovered ruins, so they hired Warner. After working with the mercenary on multiple occasions, they decided it'd be better for everyone if they formed a party. How does that sound?



Works for me! To my left is Whitley the white mage... Maybe she saved Warner's life at some point? He definitely would've taken on some risky jobs as a mercenary and adventurer, so I can see him needing the services of a healer.



Very true. Tanks are always shielding the party from the worst of their enemies' attacks, and Whitley is always willing to help someone in need. As for how she became acquainted with Draken... I'm afraid I'm drawing a blank.



Don't sweat it! I'm sure you'll think of something. Maybe they've crossed paths before, or maybe it's all business, like with Blaze and Warner. Whatever you come up with is fine by me.



Thanks. Maybe it'll come to me while we're playing!



Looks like I'm up, then. If Blaze is always seeking out knowledge, I bet they'd be interested in paying Ishgard a visit. What if our characters met when Blaze came to Draken's familial estate in search of a tome, and they've been working together ever since?



I like it! That definitely sounds like something Blaze would do.



Now that we've established how your adventurers know one another, we're ready to begin the game. The story begins in Gridania, where your party has just accepted a quest from Mother Miounne at the Carline Canopy...

SUMMARY

- The gamemaster, or GM, is responsible for running the game.
- The other players participate in the game as adventurers.
- Each player chooses a name and race for their character, then prepares an adventurer sheet.
- Players are encouraged to come up with some background for their characters, such as why they became an adventurer and how they know the other members of their party.



SCENE 2: MAKING CHECKS

Having accepted a quest from Mother Miounne, the party departs from Gridania and ventures into the Black Shroud. As they travel through the Twelveswood, the adventurers stumble upon a Lalafell in need of assistance.



You've been traveling through the Black Shroud for a bell or so, and the light filtering through the canopy suggests it's just about noon. As you walk by a narrow path winding its way through the sea of trees, you see a chocobo carriage lying on its side a short distance off. Nearby, a Lalafellin man sits atop a gnarled root, cradling his head in distress; you assume him to be the coachman.



I walk over to him and say, "What happened here, good sir?" Does everyone come with me?



[glances around cautiously] "We might be walking into a bandit ambush. I'll keep an eye on the woods and a hand on my axe."



I guess I'll go with Whitley to talk to the Lalafell. Who knows, he might even be a bandit himself.



Don't you think you're being a little too suspicious? Let's just hear him out.



The four of you greet the distressed Lalafell, who introduces himself as Nonozeo Totozeo. As you suspected, he is indeed the driver of the overturned carriage.

"I was rollin' along, mindin' my own business, when out leapt an antelope from the brush. Had to tug on the reins to keep from hittin' the heedless critter. Next thing I know, I'm careenin' through the air as my carriage takes a spill and goes crashin' to the ground. My client's expectin' this shipment by sundown, but I don't see how I'm going to make it now!"

He gestures to the carriage, which lays in the middle of the narrow path. A cart chocobo pecks at the dirt nearby, kweh-kwehing softly to itself in agitation.



Small crates litter the ground, having been thrown clear in the accident. The forest is quiet, and you don't feel as if you're being watched or deceived.



"It doesn't look like we're in any danger here." [meets the other players' eyes and nods]



"If I may, what is it that you were hauling?" If his cargo broke in the fall, there's not much we can do for him.



Is anything wrong with the carriage itself? If it needs repairs, we'll either have to find a carpenter willing to come out here and fix it or drag it back to Gridania ourselves.



I ask Nonozeo if he or his chocobo sustained any injuries in the accident.

A few of the crates splintered when they hit the ground, revealing small black nuggets of charcoal. It needs to be gathered up, but is otherwise still fit for delivery.

Now, I'd like each of you to choose one of the following actions. You're free to pick the same one, if you like.



- **Gather charcoal.** This is a simple action, so you'll succeed without having to make a check.
- **Examine the chocobo carriage.** You'll need to make an **INT** check with a CR of 10.
- **Examine Nonozeo and his chocobo for injuries.** You'll need to make a **MND** check with a CR of 10.

To make a check, roll a d20, then add the appropriate attribute from your adventurer sheet to the result. If your total equals or exceeds the CR, or challenge rating, your character succeeds.



Okay, I'll make a check to investigate the carriage. My **INT** is +5, so I just add that to whatever I roll on my d20.

Draken
Job: Dragoon
Race: Elezen

Making Checks

THE PARTY VENTURES INTO THE BLACK SHROUD ON A QUEST...

LOOK OVER THERE! THAT CARRIAGE HAS TAKEN A TUMBLE!

HO THERE, ADVENTURERS! I COULD USE A HAND, IF YOU'RE WILLIN'.

GLAD YOU ASKED! YOU'LL NEED TO ROLL A D20 AND ADD YOUR STR TO MAKE A CHECK.

A D20 IS A TWENTY-SIDED DIE, AND LOOKS LIKE THIS!

OF COURSE. ER, WHAT DO WE DO NOW?

GM

STR, EH? LET'S SEE HERE...

LOOKS LIKE MINE'S 4.

Checks

d20 + Value = Total

LV30 TANK/WARRIOR

STR +4

VIT

INT



While Blaze is doing that, I'll check Nonozeo and his chocobo for injuries.



"Draken, what say we leave them to it and see to that charcoal? Someone's got to pick it up, might as well be us." [pretends to roll up his sleeves]



I grumble, "Don't I get a say in this?" but since it doesn't look as if there's anything better to do, I help Warner gather up the cargo.



STR $9 + 5 = 14$ TOTAL



MND $14 + 5 = 19$ TOTAL



Both of you succeed on your checks.

Whitley, you look over Nonozeo and his chocobo. Fortunately they both appear to be unharmed. Blaze, the carriage's canvas cover was torn in the fall, but you don't see any other damage. The chocobo shouldn't have any trouble pulling the carriage once it's been righted. Meanwhile, Draken and Warner gather up the scattered charcoal and stack the crates in neat piles nearby.



"So now we just need to get this thing back up, eh? Not a problem." [grins and cracks his knuckles]



"Carefully, Warner, carefully. I daresay poor Nonozeo here would be ill pleased if you end up damaging his carriage in your efforts to aid him." I help Warner with the carriage to be sure he handles with care.



I will help too, for what little good it will do.



"Pretty sure me and Warner can handle this, but hey, it can't hurt." Hey GM, how do we lift the carriage?



I'll need everyone to make a STR check. I'm not going to tell you the CR this time.



STR $18 + 4 = 22$ TOTAL



STR $11 + 5 = 16$ TOTAL



STR $2 + 1 = 3$ TOTAL



STR $9 + 1 = 10$ TOTAL

Nicely done! This was a special check where you needed to get a combined total of 40 or more to succeed. Since you did, you successfully turn the carriage right-side up. And because Warner had a particularly high total, he manages to absorb the impact as your party tips the carriage back onto its wheels, ensuring it doesn't suffer any damage. With palpable relief, Nonozeo exclaims,



"Oh, thank you! If I head out now, I might just make my delivery in time! I'll leave a little somethin' for you with the folks at the Carline Canopy. Be sure to pick it up next time you're in Gridania. Fare you well!"

With that, the Lalafell secures the chocobo's harness to the carriage, clambers up into the coach, and speeds away with a flick of the reins.



[massages his shoulders] "And there he goes... Well, I guess that's our good deed for the day."



Quite so, quite so. Traveling here took two bells, and assisting Nonozeo took another bell, but there's still plenty of daylight left. You set off once more for Ul'dah...

SUMMARY

- Checks are required whenever the outcome of an action is uncertain.
- When making a check, a player rolls a d20 and adds the appropriate value—usually a primary attribute.
- If the total equals or exceeds the check's CR, the character succeeds.



SCENE 3: OPPOSITION CHECKS, PENALTIES, AND ADVANTAGE DICE

Not long after bidding farewell to Nonozeo, the party emerges from the Black Shroud and crosses into Thanalan. They continue on to Uldah, where they visit the Ruby Road Exchange in search of the individual Mother Miounne instructed them to find.

GM So, you all want to walk the streets in search of your contact, yes? In that case, tell me your adventurers' **Vigilance** scores. **Vigilance** represents how aware your adventurer is of their surroundings, and you'll find it on your adventurer sheets alongside your other secondary attributes.

Warner - WAR Got it! Mine's 11.

Draken - DRG Same.

Blaze - BLM Blaze's Vigilance is 13.

Whitley - WHM Which makes mine the highest, 15.

GM Blaze and Whitley, you notice a Hyuran woman browsing the wares of a nearby stall who matches the description of the person you're looking for. Before you can react, she looks up and meets your eye with a visible expression of startlement, then turns on her heels and runs full pelt for a nearby alley.

Whitley - WHM What!? Why is she running from us?

Blaze - BLM I sprint after her, shouting, "You there, miss! Please, hold a moment! There is something we must ask you!"

GM Okay, I'll need each of you to make a **DEX** check to see if you can follow her through the maze of alleyways. Meanwhile, I'll have the woman make a check to get away. This is an opposition check, which means we'll all compare our totals, and the character with the highest total will succeed. If that's one of you, you catch up to the fleeing woman; otherwise, she escapes your pursuit.

GM $14 \text{ DEX} + 1 = 15$

GM The woman rolled a 14. I added 1 for her **DEX**, so she has a total of 15. Now it's your turn. Draken and Warner, you take a -2 penalty on your **DEX** checks because you didn't notice her until she was already on the run.

Warner - WAR "Blast, she's a fast one!"

Draken - DRG We subtract the penalty when making our checks, right? Oof. Well, here goes...

$4 \text{ DEX} + 2 - 2 = 4$

$14 \text{ DEX} + 3 - 2 = 15$

$12 \text{ DEX} + 2 = 14$ $7 \text{ DEX} + 1 = 8$

Blaze - BLM 14! Aw, I was so close! "Come back, please!" I cry, but I assume I lose sight of her.

Whitley - WHM I can't keep pace either! Physical exertion is not my forte...

Warner - WAR [stomps in frustration] "Who ditched all this junk here!? The alley's too narrow to get around it... I can't keep up!"

Opposition Checks, Penalties, and Advantage Dice

THE PARTY IS IN PURSUIT OF A FLEEING WOMAN...

WAIT!

HOW...ARE WE SUPPOSED TO CATCH HER?

THAT'S MY CUE!

CATCH ME IF YOU CAN!

WHEN TWO CHARACTERS TAKE CONFLICTING ACTIONS, YOU MAKE AN OPPOSITION CHECK!

THIS SITUATION CALLS FOR AN OPPOSITION CHECK USING DEX.

Opposition Checks

WHM $d20 + \text{Value}$

↓

The higher total succeeds!

NPC $d20 + \text{Value}$

SO WE ROLL D20S, ADD OUR DEX, AND IF WE BEAT HER TOTAL, WE SUCCEED?

NOT SO FAST. YOU ALSO HAVE TO ACCOUNT FOR ADVANTAGE DICE AND PENALTIES!

HERE GOES!



She's not getting away from me—I use the walls and abandoned junk as footholds to launch myself into the air! GM, what happens when there's a tie?



In this case, you manage to stay right on your quarry's tail. She doesn't get away, but you don't catch up either. Let's have you and the woman make another DEX opposition check, but without the -2 penalty this time. Unfortunately, the rest of you have already fallen too far behind to have a chance of catching up, so you won't participate in this check.



What, it's all up to me? Talk about pressure... Oh, I have an idea! Can I use my **Jump** ability to close the gap?



Hmm... Technically, you return to your original position after using **Jump**, but I suppose I'll allow it in this situation. Because **Jump** lets you cover ground extremely quickly, I'll give you an advantage die on this check, too. That means you get to roll two d20s and choose which one you want to use for the check.



Great! I use **Jump** to leap into the air with lightning-quick speed, then dive for the space a few paces ahead of the woman. Here goes nothing...

$3 + 15 + 3 = 18$

$8 + 1 = 9$



That'll do it! With an 18, you easily overtake the fleeing woman.



If I'd rolled a 3 without the advantage die, she would've gotten away... Good thing I thought to use **Jump**! So I drop down right in front of her and say, "Look, lady, we're not going to hurt you. We only want to ask you a few questions."



Realizing there's nowhere left to run, the woman comes to a stop a few paces away. The rest of you can catch up now, if you want.



As I walk up, I sigh and say, "You sure led us on a merry chase, miss."



"Surely you must have had good cause for fleeing as you did. Perhaps we could find somewhere to talk things over?"



Good idea. We probably shouldn't stand around after making such a scene. "Would you be so kind as to join us at the Quicksand?"



The woman gives a nod of assent, and together you make your way to the Quicksand...

SUMMARY

- Opposition checks are used when two or more characters take conflicting actions. After all competing characters make their checks, the character with the highest total succeeds.
- Penalties may be imposed when a character makes a check under less-than-ideal circumstances. These penalties are subtracted when making the check.
- Advantage dice may be awarded when a character makes a check in favorable circumstances. When making a check with advantage dice, roll one extra d20 for each advantage die awarded, then choose which result to use for the check.

Advantage Dice



Penalties



I'll use **JUMP** to give myself the upper hand, then use the advantage die to roll two d20s!



I GOT A TOTAL OF 9...

AFTER ADDING MY DEX, I HAVE A TOTAL OF 18... WHICH MEANS I CATCH UP!

DRAKEN SUCCEEDS!

INCIDENTALLY, YOU RETURN TO YOUR ORIGINAL POSITION AFTER USING **JUMP**.

Warner
Job: Warrior
Race: Hyur

SCENE 4: ENCOUNTERS

After relocating to the Quicksand, the woman explains that she detected an aetheric disturbance coming from a cave in central Thamalan. The adventurers head out to investigate, soon discovering unusual aether radiating from the mud coating the cave's floor. Eager to complete their quest, the party heads inside in search of the source of this corruption.



GM

You emerge from the mud-lined tunnel into a round cavern, where an enormous toad-like monster has made its lair. It resembles the gigantoads you encountered on your way here, but is far larger than any you've seen before. As you approach, the creature's bulging eyes swivel towards you, and it lets out an earsplitting croak!

As you might've guessed, it's time to prepare for an encounter! Since everyone saw the gigantoad before it attacked, we don't need to worry about surprise. Give me a moment to find the encounter map... Ah, here we are. The gigantoad begins the encounter here. Go ahead and choose your starting positions from any of these starting squares.



Warner - WAR

"I wouldn't be much of a warrior if I didn't fight on the front lines!"



Draken - DRG

I've got to be up close and personal to use most of my abilities, so I'll start at the front, too.



Whitley - WHM

Allow me to provide aid from a safe distance.



Blaze - BLM

I should keep my distance as well. With luck, I'll be able to focus on casting spells without having to move around too much.



GM

Next, you need to decide on a turn order. You'll be performing your actions in this order for the duration of the encounter, so choose wisely.



Whitley - WHM

I think it would be best if I go last. That way, I can see what the rest of you do and provide healing if necessary.



Warner - WAR

"I'll charge right in and get that slimy wave-kin's attention!"



Blaze - BLM

Draken, do you want to go before me? I guess it doesn't really matter either way.



Draken - DRG

Nah, you go first. That way, I can get between you and the enemy so it has a harder time attacking you.



GM

Great, let's get this encounter underway! Round 1 kicks off with the [Adventurer Step], so go ahead and take your turns in the order you just decided. As a reminder, you can perform one primary action and one secondary action on your turn. You can also move up to your adventurer's **Speed**.



Warner - WAR

"Do your worst, toadface!" I move four squares so I'm next to the gigantoad, then use **Warrior Combo** as my primary action. I'll need to make an ability check with the gigantoad's **Defense** as the CR. Here goes!

$$12 \text{ STR} + 4 = \text{TOTAL } 16$$



GM

A 16 is enough for you to land a direct hit. What's the base effect and direct hit effect for your **Warrior Combo**?



Warner - WAR

The base effect deals 2 damage, inflicts **Enmity**, and lets me use **Storm's Path** this turn. The direct hit allows me to deal an extra 1d6 damage... I rolled a 3.





That's 2 damage for the base effect plus 3 damage for the direct hit, which means I deal a total of 5 damage. Plus, I have **Enmity** on the gigantoad now.



Your hefty axe bites deep into the gigantoad's hide, and the creature glowers down at you with a look of pure rancor.



Right then, I'll follow up with **Storm's Path**! The ability check is the same as **Warrior Combo**.

$$\text{STR } 3 + 4 = \text{TOTAL } 7$$



Unfortunately, 7 is lower than the gigantoad's **Defense**. Since it's not a direct hit, just resolve the base effect.



Bah, that's only 2 damage. I can also inflict **Enmity** and heal for 2 HP, but I already have **Enmity** on it, and I'm still at max HP, so that doesn't help me at all... Oh well. I'll use my last square of movement to step to the side, then use **Rampart** as my secondary action. Blaze, you're up!



Okay, I'll spend 1 MP to use **Thunder** as my primary action. It doesn't require an ability check, so I just resolve its base effect, which deals 3 damage and inflicts a **DOT (3)**.



You conjure a ball of lighting that discharges in a burst of sparks as it strikes the gigantoad. At the end of the enemy step, it'll take 3 damage from the **DOT (3)** you inflicted.



Since I haven't moved yet, **Thunder** allows me to use my **Consecutive Invocation** trait, which means I get to use another *invoked* ability. The only downside is that I have to give up my standard movement this turn, which is fine by me. I'll spend 2 MP to cast **Fire**, but I need to make an ability check to see if I get a direct hit. Hopefully I can beat the gigantoad's **Magic Defense**...

$$\text{INT } 9 + 5 = \text{TOTAL } 14$$



14? Yup, that's a direct hit. Go ahead and resolve **Fire**'s base and direct hit effects.



The base effect deals 3 damage and grants me the **Astral Fire** enhancement, plus an additional 1d6 damage for the direct hit. I'll go ahead and roll... That's a 6.

Boom! I hit it for 9 damage. And since I have **Astral Fire**, any *fire-aspected* abilities I use next turn deal an additional 1d6 damage. I won't recover MP at the end of the adventurer step while under its effects, so I'll use **Manafont** as my secondary action to recover 2 MP. I can't take a standard movement after using **Consecutive Invocation**, so I guess I have to end my turn here, right?



You draw upon your aether, forming it into a blazing bolt that you send streaking towards the gigantoad. The wavekin gives a pained croak as the spell explodes on impact, searing its hide.

Since you aren't taking a standard movement, you might want to focus before you end your turn. Focusing allows you to use another *secondary* ability, but like **Consecutive Invocation**, it requires you to give up your standard movement.



Oh, right! I forgot I could do that! In that case, I'll focus so I can use **Manaward**, which gives me a 2 HP barrier. That's it for me!



My turn. I move three spaces so I'm right next to the gigantoad, use **Lance Charge** for my secondary action, and then **True Thrust** as my primary action. I need to make an ability check versus the gigantoad's **Defense**.

$$\text{STR } 10 + 5 = \text{TOTAL } 15$$

Turn Order

FINALLY, CHOOSE YOUR TURN ORDER.

RIBBIT RIBBIT

YOU'LL TAKE YOUR TURNS IN THIS ORDER FOR THE DURATION OF THE ENCOUNTER.

BEFORE WE MOVE ON, I SHOULD PROBABLY REMIND YOU THAT EVERY ADVENTURER HAS ONE OF THREE ROLES:

TANK
DPS
HEALER

TANK
PROTECTS THE PARTY

DPS
DAMAGES THE PARTY'S FOES

HEALER
MENDS THE PARTY'S WOUNDS

ENEMIES TAKE THEIR TURNS AFTER THE PARTY

Whitley
Job: White Mage
Race: Lalafell



15 isn't quite enough to be a direct hit. Go ahead and resolve **True Thrust**'s base effect.



Warner scored a direct hit with a 16, so that must be its **Defense**. This won't be easy... **True Thrust**'s base effect deals 3 damage and lets me use either **Dragoon Combo** or **Disembowel**. **Lance Charge** gives me +2 to all damage this turn, so the gigantoad takes 5 damage! And before it can recover, I'll go right into **Disembowel**. Just need to roll another ability check...

$$16 + 5 = 21$$



21? Yeah, that's a direct hit.



Disembowel's base effect deals 3 damage, plus it grants me the **Power Surge** enhancement. The direct hit effect adds 1d6 damage. I rolled a 4, so that's 7, plus 2 from **Lance Charge** for a total of 9 damage. And with **Power Surge**, I'll be able to deal even more damage next round!



The point of your lance plunges deep into the gigantoad's slimy bulk. The wounded creature is well and truly infuriated now. Whitley, it's your turn.



First, I spend 1 MP to use **Aero** as my secondary action, which inflicts a **DOT (3)** on the gigantoad. None of my allies are in need of healing, so I'm free to use **Stone II** as my primary action, though it'll cost me another 1 MP. I just need to make an ability check against the gigantoad's **Magic Defense**.

$$5 + 5 = 10$$



A 10 is enough to beat its **Magic Defense** and land a direct hit.



A direct hit on a 10? This gigantoad must have a paltry **Magic Defense**.



Then it falls to us to lay it low! **Stone II**'s base effect deals 2 damage, with an additional 1d6 for the direct hit. I rolled a 1, so that's a mere 3 damage...



That's just how it goes with dice sometimes. Besides, every little bit counts! We hit the gigantoad for a total of 36 damage this round. Not bad, if you ask me.



A fair point. To end my turn, I'll move two squares away to put some space between myself and the gigantoad.



Despite your onslaught of boulders and cutting gales, the gigantoad seems hale enough to continue its rampage. Since everyone has taken a turn, your characters recover 2 MP as the [Adventurer Step] comes to an end.



That brings me back up to my maximum of 5.



Astral Fire prevents me from recovering MP naturally, so I'm still at 4 MP.



This is also when you'd suffer damage from a **DOT**, if you had any. You don't, so we'll move on to the [Enemy Step]. Like adventurers, enemies act according to their turn order. The gigantoad is alone in this encounter, so there isn't much to think about this time.



Don't forget that it takes a -5 penalty on all ability checks that don't target me since I have **Enmity** on it!



Noted. The gigantoad uses **Combo**, which lets it attack using **Lap**, then immediately uses **Vasoconstrictor**. Since Warner has **Enmity** on it, it targets him with **Lap**. I'll make an ability check against your **Defense**.

$$10 + 5 = 15$$

*ADVENTURERS CAN SPLIT THEIR MOVEMENT, ALLOWING THEM TO MOVE BOTH BEFORE AND AFTER AN ACTION.

ON YOUR TURN, YOU CAN PERFORM ONE PRIMARY AND ONE SECONDARY ACTION.

YOU CAN ALSO MOVE* UP TO YOUR SPEED.

MY TOTAL'S THE SAME AS THE GIGANTOAD'S DEFENSE!

THAT'S A DIRECT HIT, SO GO AHEAD AND RESOLVE **TOMAHAWK**'S BASE AND DIRECT HIT EFFECTS.

VERY NICE. REMEMBER, EVEN IF YOU DON'T GET A DIRECT HIT, YOU STILL GET TO RESOLVE THE ABILITY'S BASE EFFECT.

SINCE I'M THE TANK, I NEED TO INFLICT ENMITY PRONTO!

SO FOR MY MAIN ACTION, I USE **TOMAHAWK**!

MAKE AN ABILITY CHECK

TO SEE IF **TOMAHAWK** SCORES A DIRECT HIT.

MY ATTACK DEALS 1D6 + 2 DAMAGE AND INFLECTS ENMITY!

Ability Checks

d20 + Value = Total

Total ≥ CR*

IF THE TOTAL EQUALS OR EXCEEDS THE CR, THE ABILITY SCORES A DIRECT HIT!

WHEN MAKING AN ABILITY CHECK, IF YOUR TOTAL:

Equals or Exceeds the CR → **Direct Hit + Base Effect**

If Not → **Base Effect**

*THE CR FOR A PHYSICAL ABILITY'S CHECK WILL TYPICALLY BE THE TARGET'S DEFENSE, WHEREAS THE CR FOR A MAGIC ABILITY'S CHECK WILL USUALLY BE THEIR MAGIC DEFENSE.



Hah! My Defense is 16, so that's not a direct hit.



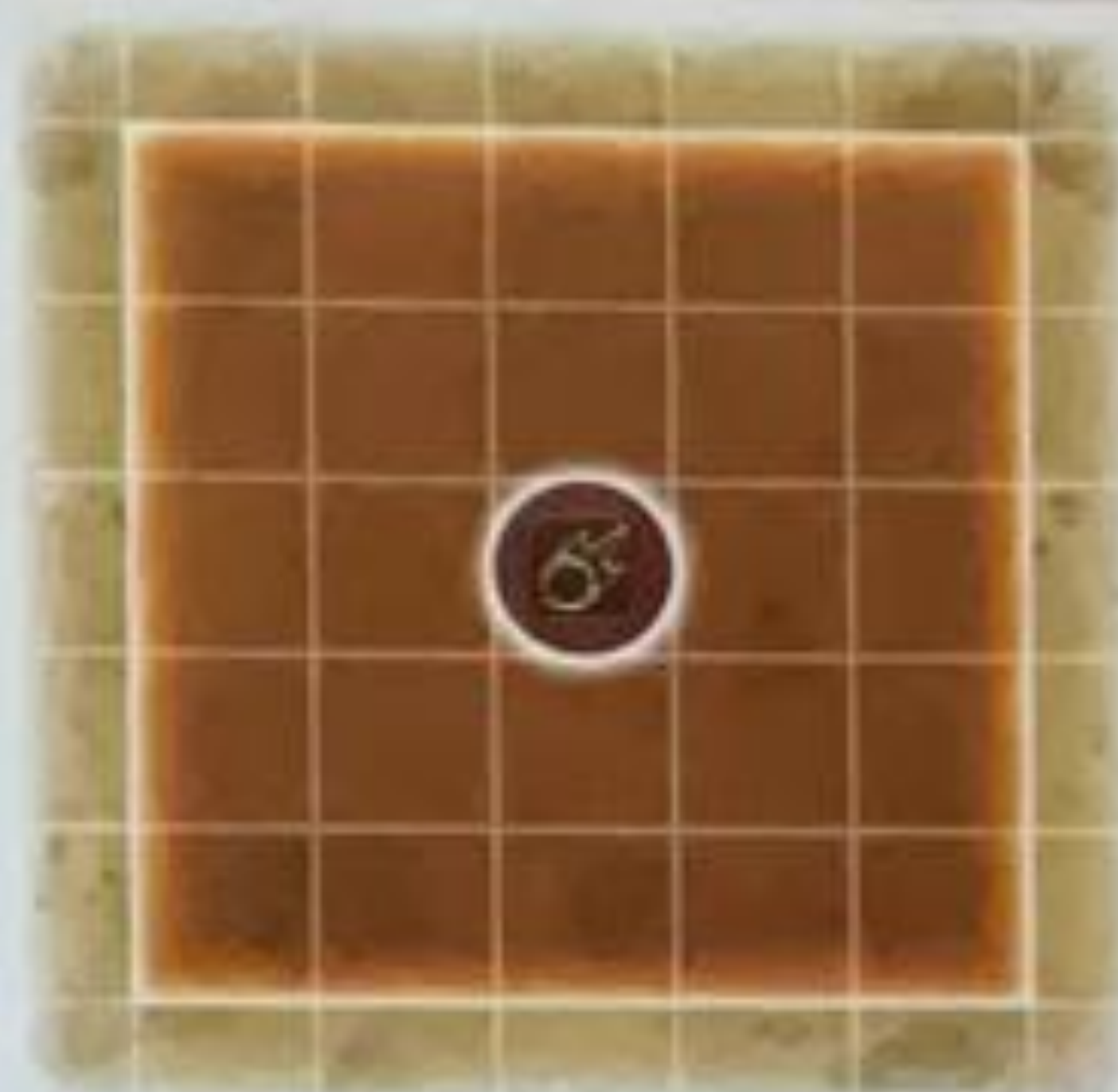
The gigantoad lashes you with its tongue, but you manage to turn just enough to avoid the brunt of the attack. You take 4 damage from the ability's base effect.



Rampart reduces the damage I take by 2, so I only lose 2 HP. "Hmph, didn't feel a thing!"



Next, the gigantoad begins making a discordant croaking sound as it uses **Vasoconstrictor**, which creates a marker centered on a random adventurer. I'll roll a die to choose which one of you it targets. 1 will be Warner, 2 will be Blaze, 3 will be Draken, and 4 will be Whitley. I'll reroll if I get a 5 or 6... That's a 2, so it generates a stationary 5x5 marker centered on Blaze.



Yikes... And what does that do?



At the start of the gigantoad's next turn, anyone inside the marker area will take 4d6 damage. Stationary markers don't move, so you can avoid damage by leaving the area before then.



Oh, that's not so bad... Wait a second, if I have to move next turn, I can't use **Consecutive Invocation**!



That's all for the gigantoad's turn. Since there aren't any other foes, this ends the [Enemy Step]. At this point, the gigantoad suffers a total of 6 damage from its DOTs: 3 from **Thunder** and 3 from **Aero**. Blaze, roll a d20 to see if **Thunder** procs.



I just need a 19 or 20! Come on... Nope, that's an 8.



Unfortunately, nothing happens. With that, round 1 ends, and a new round begins...

SUMMARY

- At the beginning of an encounter, the adventurers choose their positions and decide on the order in which they'll take their turns.
- On their turn, a character can perform one primary action, one secondary action, and a standard movement, all in the order of their choosing. Movement can be broken up into multiple small moves.
- Players attack by selecting an ability and choosing a target. An ability's base effects are always resolved.
- When an ability requires an ability check, the player rolls a d20 and adds the appropriate value. If the total exceeds the target's **Defense** or **Magic Defense**, the ability scores a direct hit.
- Each round is composed of the [Adventurer Step] and the [Enemy Step]. The adventurers take their turns first, followed by their enemies. Once all enemies have acted, the round ends and a new round begins with the [Adventurer Step].



THAT WAS JUST MY PRIMARY ACTION. I'VE STILL GOT A SECONDARY ACTION LEFT!

GOT IT. IN CASE YOU WERE WONDERING, ABILITIES LIKE **RAMPART** DON'T REQUIRE AN ABILITY CHECK.

I'LL USE **RAMPART** TO REDUCE THE DAMAGE I TAKE UNTIL MY NEXT TURN.

LOOK, THAT VILLAGER IS INJURED! AS THE PARTY'S HEALER, I CAN TEND TO THEIR WOUNDS.

HANG IN THERE!

ENEMIES GET TO ACT ONCE THE ADVENTURERS FINISH THEIR TURNS.

WHEN THEY'RE DONE, THE ROUND ENDS, AND A NEW ROUND BEGINS.

TIME FOR US DPS TO GET TO WORK! WE'LL USE OUR ABILITIES TO FELL OUR FOES!

LET'S GET TO IT!

MAGIC ABILITIES REQUIRE YOU TO SPEND MP TO USE THEM. I'LL NEED TO TAKE CARE THAT I DON'T RUN OUT.

LET ME THINK...

Round Overview

Adventurer Step				Enemy Step		Next Round
WAR's Turn	BLM's Turn	DRG's Turn	WHM's Turn	Enemy A's Turn	Enemy B's Turn	

Blaze
Job: Black Mage
Race: Miqu'te

SCENE 5: CRITICALS AND LIMIT BREAKS

The party engages a massive gigantoad in the cavern's depths in hopes of cleansing the area of corrupted aether. Yet after a protracted conflict, they are dismayed to find their foe yet stands.



"Didn't think a gigantoad could take this much punishment... We might've underestimated this ball of slime!"



That's the end of my turn, and I'm all out of MP! I already used **Manafont** and **Lucid Dreaming**, and since I can only use them once per phase, there's not much I can do to recover MP now...



Does that mean you can't use them again during this encounter?



Not necessarily. Most encounters end after a single phase, in which case, yes, those abilities can't be used again in the encounter. However, some encounters have multiple phases, which begin once certain conditions have been met. New phases are often accompanied by the arrival of enemy or allied reinforcements, changes to the encounter map, or the transformation of a foe.



So you're saying that when a new phase begins, abilities with limited uses can be used again. That's great and all, but right now, we need to focus on finishing off this gigantoad!

Last turn, I had to back away from it to avoid a marker, so instead of moving in again, I'll use **Jump** as my primary action. Before that, though, I'll use **Life Surge** as my secondary action, then focus so I can use **Lance Charge** as well. That'll give me an advantage die on **Jump**'s ability check!

+5 = TOTAL 25



Natural 20 (🎲)! That's a critical!



Congrats! If you roll a critical on an ability check, you get to double any dice for the ability's base and direct hit effects.



Jump's base effect deals $2d6 + 3$ damage, and the direct hit effect adds another $2d6$. I get to roll twice as many dice, which means... My attack deals $8d6 + 3$ damage!



= TOTAL 29



That's not all! **Lance Charge** gives me +2 to damage, as does **Power Surge**. Add the +3 from the base effect, and that's a total of 36 damage!



"There's no way it'll survive that!"



"Famous last words, Warner..."



You leap into the air, then thrust your lance deep into the enormous gigantoad's back. The creature lets loose a cry of agony that sends tremors through the cavern before collapsing to the muddy ground.

But before you can breathe a sigh of relief, the vile miasma seeping from the creature's skin surges up to engulf its massive form.



...We're not done here, are we?



That's right. Encounters continue until the end of the [Adventurer Step] or the [Enemy Step] in which all enemies are defeated, so the [Adventurer Step] can't end until you and Whitley finish your turns.



Well, I'm all set. Something tells me there's going to be a second phase to this encounter.





I agree. Before I take my turn, I'd like to know what happens when a new phase begins. Do we recover our HP and MP?



HP, MP, and benefits from traits carry over between phases, but all active enhancements and enfeeblements are removed.



It sounds as if I should tend to my fellow adventurers' wounds as best I can while preserving enough MP in case something unexpected happens. I'm running low on MP, so I use **Cure** as my secondary action to heal Warner, and make an ability check to see if it scores a critical... No, that's a 1. Still, I heal our tank for 1d6 HP. I rolled a...4!



Thanks! I'm still down a few HP, but I'll be okay.



I'd prefer to save my remaining MP for the next phase, so I'll end my turn here.



That ends the [Adventurer Step], so you recover MP. But as you've already surmised, the encounter isn't over yet!

Miasma covers the slain gigantoad until finally, the creature rises unsteadily to its feet, transformed into a being of ever-shifting shadow. The shade of your fallen foe fixes you with a baleful glare. Thus begins phase two!



Since this is a new phase, I can use **Manafont** again! I'm not out of the fight just yet!



For this encounter, your positions carry over into the second phase. The encounter map remains the same and no new enemies appear, but the gigantoad has clearly taken on a different form. There's a good chance its attributes and abilities have changed as well.

As you face down this twisted foe, a powerful desire to survive wells up within. You are now able to use limit breaks!



Awesome! Do we all get to use them?



Your party can use a total of three limit breaks per encounter, so you'll have to decide who will use them. Once an adventurer uses a limit break, they can't do so again during that encounter.



I see. We'll need to choose our moment well.



"Guess I'll have to push through the pain... Come on, then!"



The first round of the second phase begins with the adventurer step. Warner, you're up.

AND SO THE GAME CONTINUES...

SUMMARY

- If a player gets a natural 20 on an ability check, they score a critical, which allows them to roll twice as many dice for the ability's damage dealing or healing effects.
- Most encounters consist of a single phase that ends when all enemies have been defeated. Some encounters, however, have multiple phases.
- The GM will inform the players when they can use limit breaks. Each adventurer can use a single limit break during a given encounter, and the party can use no more than three total.





CHAPTER 1: GETTING STARTED

COMMONLY USED TERMS

Gamemaster (GM)

The player who accepts the mantle of Gamemaster—or GM—will be your guide to the myriad adventures that await you in the Final Fantasy XIV TTRPG.

The GM describes the world the player characters inhabit and any situations they encounter. They also assume control of any non-player characters or monsters the adventurers come across.

Players

Aside from the GM, each player will play as an adventurer—their very own character within the game world. In most games, a given player will control a single adventurer.

Scenarios

Scenarios are collections of story beats and encounters prepared in advance by the GM. These will make up the bulk of the setting for your adventures.

While you are more than welcome to use the official scenarios that are available for purchase, you can—and are encouraged to—craft your own adventures as well. Building your own story can be a lot of fun!

Adventurers (Player Characters)

Intrepid inhabitants of Hydaelyn, adventurers seek out challenges to surmount and mysteries to unravel. The adventurers controlled by the players are also known as player characters.

You can choose to play as a premade adventurer, or create your own adventurer by following the steps outlined in the Standard Rulebook.

NPCs (Non-Player Characters)

The diverse beings who live on Hydaelyn but aren't player characters are called NPCs. NPCs are almost always controlled by the GM.

Monsters

Hostile NPCs are frequently referred to as monsters in the game's rules and scenarios. This is a general term that can encompass humanoid and otherworldly foes in addition to beasts of fang and claw.

Characters

All beings who reside on Hydaelyn and can be affected by the various forces and effects outlined in the game's rules are collectively referred to as characters. This includes adventurers, NPCs, and monsters.

Effects that can be applied to a character will impact adventurers, NPCs, and monsters in the same way.

Allies

Characters who are aligned in cause or purpose with the adventurers are considered to be allies.

Adventurers are allied with the other members of their party, as well as with any NPCs helping them. Monsters are allied with other monsters that are attacking the adventurers, as well as with any NPCs controlling them through means magical or mundane. Ultimately, the GM has the final say as to whether two characters are allies.

Enemies

Characters who oppose each other or are otherwise hostile are considered to be enemies.

Adventurers consider the monsters that attack them and the NPCs that harbor malicious intent towards the people of Hydaelyn to be enemies. Monsters, on the other hand, generally view the adventurers and any NPCs belonging to a Grand Company as enemies.

Ultimately, the GM has the final say as to whether two characters are enemies.

Dice

Dice rolls are used to determine whether certain actions succeed or fail. Dice come in a variety of shapes and sizes. In the game's rules and scenarios, dice are referred to by using the letter **d** followed by the number of sides. For example, **d20** refers to a twenty-sided die.

Sometimes, you'll need to roll multiple dice at once. This is indicated by a number before the letter **d**. For example, if you see **3d6**, you need to roll three six-sided dice.

Dice rolls can have modifiers, which are indicated by a plus or minus after the dice to be rolled. **2d6 + 4** means you roll two six-sided dice, add them together, then add 4 to the total.

These modifiers can also refer to a character's attributes. **d20 + STR** means you roll a twenty-sided die and add your character's **STR**.

PLAYING THE GAME

Player groups will generally play through scenarios by following this basic pattern:

1. The GM describes the situation in which the adventurers find themselves.
2. The players tell the GM what actions their adventurers take.
3. The GM describes what effect the adventurers' actions have had on the situation. If an adventurer attempts to perform a challenging action, the GM will ask that player to make a check to see if their efforts succeed.
4. Return to step 1 and repeat to continue the adventure.

Players should have their adventurer sheets on hand at all times during the game. Meanwhile, the GM will frequently need to refer to the scenario to review information for NPCs and items that show up during an adventure.

THE GOLDEN RULE

This game was designed to provide a framework that allows you to embark on exciting and memorable adventures in the magical world of Final Fantasy XIV. The ultimate goal is to have fun with your friends, and for this to work, all participants need to be considerate and respectful of one another while playing.

The GM is the architect of your adventure, curating the events that occur as you progress through the scenario. At times, they may decide to handle things in a way that differs from these rules or from other tabletop games you've played. When this happens, always remember that their main goal is to facilitate an exciting journey for your adventurers.

Their decision might stem from a special rule that applies to a monster in the scenario, or could simply be that they're bending the rules in order to enhance the story for everyone involved. Players are not privy to the rationale behind such decisions, and in the end, the GM has the final say in all game-related matters.

Of course, the GM's discretionary powers are limited to the game alone. GMs cannot make decisions about matters outside of the game without the consent of their players, nor do they have the right to force players to do anything they aren't comfortable with.

Keep in mind that while the GM may control monsters and other foes, you aren't playing against them. **The people at your gaming table are friends with whom you're collaborating to create a story.**

GMs are not infallible. As the GM, if you are ever uncertain as to how to proceed, don't hesitate to consult with the other players. Together, you'll find a way to continue the game that will be fun for everyone involved.

Players are encouraged to work with their GM and are free to offer suggestions that could make the game more enjoyable. So long as these ideas fit the scenario and don't derail the story, the GM should make an effort to incorporate player feedback into their game.

Following this golden rule will help make your adventure more enjoyable. It's okay to encourage other players to share this mindset, and to respectfully raise issues should something go awry. And above all else, remember the point of the game: to have fun!



MAKING CHECKS

When a character takes an action where the outcome is uncertain or is dependent on the skill with which the action is performed, the player controlling that character rolls a d20 to determine success or failure.

Follow these three steps when making a check:

1. Determine the type of check required and assign a challenge rating.
2. Roll a d20 and apply any relevant modifiers.
3. Determine the success or failure of the action.

1. Determining Check Type and Assigning Challenge Ratings

The GM determines the type of check required and assigns it a challenge rating (CR) appropriate to the action the character is attempting. For example, attempting to lift a toppled carriage would require a **STR** check, whereas trying to decipher an encoded journal would require an **INT** check.

Attributes such as **STR** and **INT** are explained on page 21.

- If a check is required to determine success or failure when a character performs an action or uses an ability outside of an encounter, the GM will first determine the appropriate value to use for that check—usually a primary attribute. Then, they will assign a CR based on the scenario, the ability in question, or the Challenge Rating Reference Table.
- Ability checks are used to determine how successful a character is when using an ability in an encounter. When making an ability check, the ability being used indicates the value and CR for the check.

Challenge Rating Reference Table

Easy	5	Very Hard	20
Average	10	Extremely Hard	25
Hard	15	Nearly Impossible	30

The Challenge Rating Reference Table is intended merely as a point of reference, and may be adjusted to suit the check being made. For example, if an adventurer is attempting something slightly harder than average, you could assign it a CR of 11. If the task is hard but still within their capabilities, you could assign it a CR of 18.

2. Rolling Dice and Applying Modifiers

To make a check, roll a d20 and add the appropriate value. Then add or subtract any modifiers conferred by traits, abilities, enhancements, or enfeeblements.

3. Determining Success or Failure

If the total from step 2 equals or exceeds the target CR, your character succeeds. If the total is lower than the target CR, their attempt ends in failure, or succeeds in an unexpected manner that results in an undesirable outcome. The GM will describe what happens as a result of the check according to the scenario or their own judgment.

WHEN (NOT) TO MAKE CHECKS

Not all actions require a check—a hale adventurer will have little trouble rising from their bed, strapping on their arms and armor, and leaving their inn room. Such tasks come naturally, and are therefore guaranteed to succeed.

The same applies to actions where a character's efforts are guaranteed to fail. No matter how skilled they may be, an adventurer hurling a pebble into the mouth of a cave can't expect their throw to kill a powerful monster deep within. The best they could hope for would be to scare off a few cave bats.

As a general rule, you only need to make checks if the outcome of an action is uncertain.

Example 1: A paladin is walking down the road towards the Silver Bazaar when they come across an overturned chocobo carriage. The coachman, upon noticing the adventurer's approach, beseeches them to right the toppled vehicle.

As an attempt to lift the carriage is a somewhat physically challenging endeavor that could end in failure, the GM calls for a **STR** check with a CR of 13 to see if the paladin's muscles are up to the task.

The player rolls a d20, which lands on 11. Their adventurer's **STR** is +4, meaning their total is 15. This exceeds the check's CR, so the paladin successfully lifts the carriage!

GM: *You take hold of the upended carriage and heave with all your might. Slowly, you raise it from the ground and set it back on the road.*

Example 2: While researching an ancient ruin, a black mage stumbles upon a journal written using a complex cipher. Curious, they try to decode it.

As an attempt to break this particularly difficult cipher is a mentally challenging task that has a high chance of ending in failure, the GM calls for an **INT** check with a CR of 17.

The player rolls a d20, which lands on 9. Their adventurer's **INT** is +5, giving them a total of 14. As this falls short of the check's CR, the black mage fails to make sense of the journal.

GM: *You run through every method you can think of to crack the code, but are unable to unravel the journal's secrets.*

ADVANTAGE DICE

Some traits, abilities, enhancements, and situations will grant advantage dice. Advantage dice allow you to roll extra d20s when making certain checks.

For example, if you have two advantage dice when making a check, you would roll a total of three d20s for that check. After rolling your d20s, choose one of the results to use for the check. Take care that you do not add the results together by mistake!

Example 1: A scholar has a trait that gives them one advantage die on checks related to studying tomes and scrolls.

Hoping to discover information about a lost civilization in an ancient scroll, the player makes an **INT** check with a CR of 12. Because their trait gives them one advantage die, they roll two d20s, which land on 8 and 12. They choose to use the higher roll of 12, and add their adventurer's **INT** (+3) for a total of 15—a success!

GM: *You swiftly pore over the scroll and locate the information you seek.*

Example 2: A ninja has an ability that gives them two advantage dice on ability checks.

During an encounter, this adventurer uses **Throwing Dagger** on a villager being controlled by an enemy NPC in an attempt to render them unconscious. This requires them to make an ability check using their **DEX**, with a CR determined by the target's **Defense**. The player rolls three d20s, which land on 1, 17, and 20. Worried that using too high a result could deal too much damage and seriously harm the innocent villager, the player chooses to use the 1. They add their adventurer's **DEX** (+5) for a total of 6.

GM: *The total is less than the villager's **Defense**, so **Throwing Dagger** deals just enough damage to knock them out.*

PENALTIES

Some traits, abilities, enfeeblements, and situations will impose penalties when making certain checks.

Penalties are applied after you roll a d20 and add or subtract all applicable modifiers. If multiple penalties apply to a single check, use the largest of them and ignore the others.

Example: A warrior is suffering from a -3 penalty to **STR** checks due to the effect of an ability, and a -2 penalty to all checks due to the **Slow** enfeeblement.

This adventurer attempts to hold up a collapsing wall, which requires a **STR** check with a CR of 15. The player rolls a d20, which lands on 16. They then add their adventurer's **STR** (+4) for a total of 20. Because both penalties mentioned above affect this roll, they apply the larger of the two (-3), reducing their total to 17.

Even with the penalty, the warrior succeeds and is able to keep the wall from crushing their allies!

ADVANTAGE DICE AND PENALTIES

At times, circumstances may require you to make a check involving both advantage dice and penalties. When making such a check, roll your d20s, choose one of the results to use, and apply modifiers and penalties as you would for any other check.

Example: A monk has a trait that gives them one advantage die on **DEX** checks to escape from rope bindings. However, they've been captured by bandits, tied to a chair, and badly injured during a vicious interrogation. The GM rules that this imposes a -5 penalty on all checks.

The player makes a **DEX** check with a CR of 12 to slip free from the ropes. They roll two d20s, which land on 12 and 13. They choose to use the 13, then add their adventurer's **DEX** (+3) for a total of 16. This would be a success were it not for the -5 penalty, which reduces their total to 11.

GM: *You manage to undo the bonds, but as you shrug off the ropes, you knock over the chair you were tied to. The noise draws attention, and you hear the footfalls of your bandit captors approaching your cell...*

The adventurer isn't out of danger just yet!



OPPOSITION CHECKS

Sometimes two or more characters take conflicting actions, each hoping to achieve different ends. In such cases, the outcome is determined by making an opposition check.

In an opposition check, all characters involved make a check appropriate for the action they're attempting and compare their totals. The character with the highest total succeeds in their attempt.

When this results in a tie, oftentimes nothing will happen—the situation simply remains as it was before the check was made. However, ties may also lead to complex or unexpected outcomes, such as all characters succeeding in their efforts or collectively failing spectacularly. The GM will use the scenario and their own judgment to determine what happens in such cases.

Example 1: A dragoon and a bard spot gil lying in the middle of the road and race to pick it up. To determine which character reaches the fallen coin first, the GM has them make an opposition check using **DEX**.

The dragoon's player rolls a 3 and adds their adventurer's **DEX** (+3) for a total of 6.

At the same time, the bard's player rolls a 2 and adds their adventurer's **DEX** (+4) for a total of 6.

As both players ended up with the same total, the check results in a stalemate!

Thinking it would make for an amusing story, the GM decides that both players reach the gil at the same time. In their haste to snatch it up, they inadvertently launch the gil heavensward, and watch, stunned, as it disappears into the distance.

Example 2: The selfsame dragoon and bard search frantically to find the lost gil. To determine which character finds it first, the GM has them make an opposition check using **MND**.

The dragoon's player rolls a 13 and adds their adventurer's **MND** (+1) for a total of 14.

The bard, however, has a trait that gives them one advantage die on **MND** checks to find objects that gleam or glitter. Their player rolls two d20s, which land on 8 and 4. They choose to use the 8, and add their adventurer's **MND** (+2) for a total of 10.

As the dragoon's total exceeds the bard's, the dragoon finds the gil first, slips it into their purse, and skips merrily away along the road, humming a jovial ditty. The bard slumps their shoulders in defeat, disappointed to have lost their prize.

ADVENTURERS

Adventurers are the avatars through which players can experience the wondrous adventures that await them on Hydaelyn.

Before starting the game, you'll need to prepare an adventurer sheet that summarizes everything you need to know about your adventurer. Three types of information determine who your adventurer is and what they can do: their job, their attributes, and their profile.

Similar info exists for NPCs and monsters, but is often abbreviated. NPCs and monsters may also have features that player characters do not.

JOBS

Every adventurer has a job that determines their attributes, traits, and abilities.

As your adventurer explores the world and overcomes challenges and mighty foes, their job will level up. Leveling up an adventurer's job can grant them new traits and abilities, or alter the effects of those they already have. Your GM will let you know in advance what level of adventurer to prepare in order to tackle a given scenario.

Roles

Jobs are divided into different roles which help define their responsibilities during encounters. The three roles are **tank**, **healer**, and **DPS**.

The most common light party—a party of four adventurers—is composed of one healer, one tank, and two DPS characters. Official scenarios are often designed with this party size and composition in mind.



Tanks

Tanks are stalwart defenders who shield the party from danger. By drawing enmity and bearing the brunt of their enemies' attacks, they allow their allies to maneuver and excel.



Healers

Whether it be restoring HP or removing enfeeblements, healers are the ones who keep the party fighting fit. Their support is often key to victory.



DPS

DPS characters are the damage dealers of the party. Though they vary in their methodology, they all share the ability to bring their enemies low.

TRAITS

Traits are special characteristics and talents your adventurer possesses. Unless otherwise stated, traits are always active, and their effects cannot be lost or removed.

Size

Characters occupy space within the world of Hydaelyn, and as such, possess a size trait that approximates their physical dimensions. Most adventurers are **medium** size, which means they take up a 1x1 square of space on an encounter map.

NPCs and monsters come in all shapes and sizes, and may be much larger or smaller than an adventurer. For more information on the different sizes in this game, see page 26.

ABILITIES

Abilities are the different skills and spells your adventurer can wield during encounters. Unlike traits, abilities must be used to take effect.

Abilities can also be used outside of an encounter, though doing so requires the GM's approval. For more information on abilities, see page 26.

Additional Traits and Abilities

Over the course of a scenario, adventurers may learn or discover additional traits and abilities. Unless otherwise stated, these additional traits and abilities can only be used during the scenario in which they're obtained.

If you feel that an exception should be made, and that doing so will make the story more enjoyable for everyone involved, don't hesitate to share your opinion with the GM and the other players. If everyone agrees, you may carry over additional traits and abilities from previous scenarios or add new traits or abilities to your game.



ATTRIBUTES

An adventurer's attributes determine their strengths and weaknesses. The higher an attribute, the more capable the adventurer is at performing related actions.

Primary Attributes

Primary attributes are a numerical representation of a character's physical and mental characteristics. While an average popoto farmer's primary attributes are unlikely to exceed 0, adventurers are exceptional beings and their primary attributes reflect this.

Keep in mind that most of the checks you make during the game will rely on your primary attributes.

STR

STR represents your adventurer's athleticism, physical fitness, and the raw power they can bring to bear.

This attribute is used when employing physical force to overcome a situation, such as lifting a boulder, pushing or pulling a laden cart, or kicking down a door.

DEX

DEX represents your adventurer's coordination, agility, reflexes, and balance.

This attribute is used when sneaking, performing precision tasks, or traversing narrow ledges.

VIT

VIT represents your adventurer's hardiness, physical health, and endurance.

This attribute is used when holding one's breath, performing manual labor for long periods of time, or attempting to survive in a desert without water.

INT

INT represents your adventurer's sharpness of mind, ability to recall information, and reasoning skills.

This attribute is used when attempting to reach a logical conclusion, trying to remember a relevant fact, or searching for hidden objects.

MND

MND represents your adventurer's perceptiveness, instincts, and intuition.

This attribute is used when discerning someone's intent from their gestures, understanding how another person is feeling, noticing when something is out of place, or treating another character's wounds.

Secondary Attributes

Secondary attributes are most frequently used during encounters, although they are occasionally used for checks outside of encounters as well.

Like primary attributes, an adventurer's secondary attributes are determined by their job and traits. However, in rare cases, an adventurer's personal history and background can influence their secondary attributes as well.

Defense

Defense represents your adventurer's ability to withstand physical forces.

This attribute is often used as the CR for the ability checks an enemy makes when attacking your adventurer with a *physical* ability.

Magic Defense

Magic Defense represents your adventurer's ability to withstand magical forces.

This attribute is often used as the CR for the ability checks an enemy makes when attacking your adventurer with a *magic* ability.

Speed

Speed represents the distance your adventurer can move on their turn when performing a standard movement action.

Vigilance

Vigilance is a passive attribute that represents how aware your adventurer is of their surroundings at any given time.

This attribute is typically not used to make checks; rather, the GM will use an adventurer's **Vigilance** to determine what they notice about their environment. Be sure to tell the GM your adventurer's **Vigilance** when starting a new scenario.

Max HP

Max HP determines how much HP your adventurer has. If their HP ever falls to zero, they lose consciousness and are unable to continue participating in an encounter.

As HP is not a measure of wellness or physique, an adventurer's vitality does not influence their **Max HP**. For more information on HP, see page 31.

Max MP

Max MP determines how much MP your adventurer has. Some abilities require adventurers to spend MP to use them. In most cases, characters have a **Max MP** of 5.

ADVENTURER PROFILE

Your adventurer is more than a walking collection of numbers—they're a living, breathing part of the world. That's why every adventurer has a profile that describes the kind of person they are.

Consider the following questions when writing your adventurer's profile:

- What race are they?
- What do they look like?
- Where were they born, and how were they raised?
- Why did they decide to become an adventurer?
- What are their likes and dislikes?
- Do they have any friends or family?

Be sure to consult with the GM and the other players to ensure your profile is appropriate to the scenario before you begin playing.

While your adventurer's profile will only rarely influence game mechanics such as traits or secondary attributes, the information it contains can have a significant impact on how a scenario's story unfolds.

Say your current quest requires you to speak with an Ala Mhigan refugee. If a member of your party is a fellow Ala Mhigan, the refugee might be more receptive to lending you aid.

Conversely, if you visit a settlement where people hold a grudge against Gridania due to an incident several years prior, they won't be happy to see an adventurer belonging to the Wood Wailers. In some cases, they may even become hostile and attack!

As per the golden rule, the GM has the final say about how an adventurer's profile impacts the story. If the GM is concerned as to how certain information in a profile could affect the game, it's often best to ignore it.

If, for example, an adventurer's profile mentions that they're the illegitimate child of Buscarron—proprietor of Buscarron's Druthers—it's perfectly all right for the GM to have Buscarron address this adventurer as a complete stranger should you visit his alchouse in the Upper Paths.

It may be that the adventurer is a habitual liar, or Buscarron and his scion could have a reason to pretend they don't know each other. The GM is free to advance the story without exploring this alleged familial relationship.

Titles

Titles serve as a record of an adventurer's deeds and accomplishments, and are a rewarding way to track a character's journey across Eorzea and beyond.

Titles aren't just for show—they can also have a tangible effect on the story. An adventurer's bearing subtly shifts when using a title, allowing NPCs within the game world to intuit what that title is. This may cause them to behave differently towards that character—for better or for worse.

In rare cases, a title may even grant effects that influence the mechanics of the game itself. Keep in mind that the GM has final say on whether a title affects the game.

Adventurers may possess as many titles as they can earn, but can only use one title at any given time. Using a title is optional, but unused titles will not have an effect on the scenario. Titles can be swapped while resting or sleeping, but cannot be changed otherwise.

Starter Set Scenario Titles

Cellica's Brave Adventurer

- **Effect:** Recover 1d6 HP at the start of each new encounter phase.

Mine Drinkin' Buddy

- **Effect:** You know how to feast and make merry, even in the company of strangers. This title has no effect during encounters.

Lazy for Laurence

- **Effect:** You may ask the GM to reveal the defense of any seedkin characters on an encounter map.

Supplementary Profile Fields

Character profiles also contain additional fields for supplementary information. More information on supplementary profile fields can be found in the Standard Rulebook.





CHAPTER 2: ENCOUNTERS

THE BASICS

Encounters are urgent situations in which the specifics of each character's actions take center stage. These can include clashes with monsters, tense escapes from crumbling ruins, or even desperate struggles for the very fate of the star. Encounters take place on an **encounter map**, upon which participating characters battle and maneuver. A square grid should be used to represent the encounter map, with miniatures or other markers to keep track of character positions.

Encounters are divided up into three distinct units of time: **phases**, **rounds**, and **turns**. Most encounters have only one phase, but special or complex encounters may be composed of multiple phases. For more information on phases, see page 31.

STARTING AN ENCOUNTER

Before starting the first round of an encounter, determine the following:

1. **Surprise:** The GM determines whether any of the characters participating in the encounter have been caught by surprise.
2. **Positioning:** The GM determines the positions of all enemies participating in the encounter and places them in the appropriate squares of the map. Depending on the scenario, the GM will either specify a starting area in which the players may freely place their adventurers, or place the adventurers in specific locations.
3. **Turn Order:** Players determine the order in which their adventurers and allies take their turns. This is referred to as the turn order. The turn order for enemies is determined by the scenario, or left to the discretion of the GM. The GM may choose to share this information with the other players, but is not required to do so. Once the turn order has been set, it cannot be changed for the duration of the encounter, unless otherwise specified.

ROUNDS

A round refers to the period of time in which all characters participating in an encounter take a single turn.

Each round is composed of the following three steps:

1. **[Adventurer Step]:** Each adventurer and allied character participating in the encounter takes a turn, following the turn order. If the encounter hasn't ended after they have done so, proceed to the [Enemy Step].
2. **[Enemy Step]:** Each enemy participating in the encounter takes a turn. If the encounter hasn't ended after they have done so, end the round.
3. **[End of Round Step]:** The current round ends, a new round begins, and the order of play starts over at the [Adventurer Step].

At the end of each step, the GM determines if the encounter continues. If the adventurers have made it out of danger or have defeated all enemy characters, the encounter ends or proceeds to the next phase.

Sometimes, a character's abilities, enhancements, or enfeeblements will have effects that activate or need to be resolved at the end of a given step. Always resolve effects that impact adventurers before resolving those that affect enemies. Should multiple effects need to be resolved simultaneously, the adventurers may decide the order in which to do so.

When there are multiple hostile factions participating in an encounter, all the characters from one faction will take their turns, followed by those of the next faction. The turn order for factions is determined by the GM, and cannot be changed for the duration of the encounter.

SURPRISE

Certain situations may cause an encounter to begin with one faction taking the other by surprise. If, for example, a hidden enemy launches an attack against the adventurers, any characters caught by surprise cannot act on their turn or use *instant* abilities during the first round of the encounter.

Be aware that it is possible for some characters belonging to a faction to be taken by surprise while other characters are not. The GM will determine which characters are caught by surprise in any given encounter.

TURNS

When a character is involved in an encounter, they may perform several different actions during their turn. Each turn, they can perform one of each of the following:

- A primary action
- A secondary action
- Standard movement or focus

You may choose the order in which your adventurer performs these actions, or opt to end your turn without performing some or all of them. When there are no further actions you can or wish to take on your turn, declare your turn to be finished and proceed to either the next adventurer's turn or the next step of the round.

The GM will also take turns for NPCs and monsters in the manner described above.

Primary Actions

On a character's turn, they may perform one of the following primary actions:

- Use a *primary* ability
- Use a *primary* item
- **Sprint**, doubling the character's **Speed** for this turn
- Perform any other action specified by the scenario or the GM to be a primary action
- Perform a secondary action

Combo Abilities

Some abilities have special effects that allow you to use an additional primary ability, exceeding the usual limit of one primary action per turn. These abilities are referred to as combo abilities, and will specify the additional abilities you may choose from. While you are not required to use an additional ability, you cannot use an ability that is not indicated by the combo ability.

Secondary Actions

On a character's turn, they may perform one of the following secondary actions:

- Use a *secondary* ability
- Use a *secondary* item
- Perform any other action specified by the scenario or the GM to be a secondary action

Standard Movement

Characters often need to remain mobile during encounters to stay out of harm's way or position themselves more favorably. By using a standard movement action, a character can move between different squares during their turn so long as the number of squares traversed does not exceed their **Speed**. Moving into an adjacent square costs one square of movement, regardless of whether that square is orthogonally or diagonally adjacent. When counting squares for movement, do not include your starting square.

Characters cannot pass through squares that contain an enemy, unless that enemy is smaller in size than that character (see page 26). However, they may pass through squares occupied by allied or neutral characters, regardless of size. Additionally, a character cannot end a standard movement action in a square occupied by another character. If a character would run out of movement in a square in which another character is present, they cannot enter that square.

You may also choose to split up a character's standard movement and have them pause to perform primary or secondary actions. Afterwards, they are free to continue their move, as long as they have movement left to use.

Example: An adventurer with a **Speed** of five squares begins their turn. They move two squares, perform a primary action, move one square, and then perform a secondary action. Finally, they use the last two squares of their standard movement action to move again before ending their turn.

Focus

A character may forgo all standard movement during their turn to focus. This allows them to perform an additional secondary action, for a total of two secondary actions in a single turn. The character stands still to focus on their actions and can't spare a thought for mobility.

Free Actions

In addition to a primary action, a secondary action, and a standard movement action, a character may also perform one free action during their turn, provided that action is permitted by the rules and the GM. Free actions typically involve doing something simple, like opening a door, picking up an item, or sounding a warning whistle.

The GM is the final arbiter on whether or not an action can be carried out as a free action, but in general, it's safe to assume that anything that can be accomplished almost instantaneously and with a negligible chance of failure can be performed as a free action. Any action that takes even a little time—such as unlocking a coffer or turning a crank to lower a drawbridge—or that requires the character to make a check must be performed as a primary action.



Instant Abilities

Characters can react to the ever-changing circumstances of an encounter by using *instant* abilities.

Unlike other abilities, *instant* abilities may be used during any character's turn, provided their trigger conditions are met. However, a character cannot use *instant* abilities when they are surprised, nor can they use multiple *instant* abilities on a given turn.

Example: During an enemy's turn, a warrior uses **Interject** in response to an ability used by that enemy. They cannot then use **Thrill of Battle**, another *instant* ability, in response to that same ability, as it is still the same character's turn. They may, however, use **Thrill of Battle** in response to another ability on the next character's turn.

If an *instant* ability is used during another character's turn, that character can continue their turn as soon as the *instant* ability's effect is resolved.



Movement Effects

Movement that occurs as a result of an ability's effect, a character trait, or an encounter mechanic is referred to as a movement effect. This is considered distinct from standard movement.

For this reason, a character can still move via a movement effect even after using all of their standard movement. Movement effects do not change the distance a character can move when performing a standard movement action on a given turn; they are simply a secondary source of mobility.

Example: A dragoon uses the **Elusive Jump** ability as a secondary action, which allows them to move five squares. As they have not used any of their standard movement, they may still travel as far as their **Speed** allows, or choose to focus and perform an additional secondary action.

Unless otherwise specified, a movement effect cannot cause a character to stop in a square occupied by another character, even temporarily. This applies to abilities and traits that move other characters as well.

If resolving an effect results in a situation where multiple characters end up in the same square, refer to the following section on size for more information on how to proceed.



CHARACTER SIZE

Depending on their size, characters take up different amounts of space. The table below shows how much space characters of each size take up during an encounter.

This table can also be used to determine the size of inanimate objects that take up space on the encounter map.

Size	Space Occupied	Size	Space Occupied
Small	1×1 square	Medium	1×1 square
Large	2×2 squares	Huge	3×3 squares
Colossal	4×4 squares+		

The space occupied by a character represents the number of squares that character controls in an encounter. Most medium-sized characters aren't so broad as to physically fill an entire square, but their ability to take a swing at or push back any foes who encroach on their space causes them to take up one full square.

Consider the following: Two medium-sized Sahagin are standing side by side in a passageway two squares wide. Their enemies—a small-sized character and a medium-sized character—cannot pass by the Sahagin without running afoul of their tridents. A large-sized character, however, could shove past them without issue.



If resolving an effect results in a situation where multiple characters end up in the same square, the GM will move one or more characters to the closest unoccupied square.

If a square is occupied by characters of differing sizes, the GM moves the smaller of the characters to a different square; if the characters are the same size, but one is an adventurer and the other an NPC, the GM moves the adventurer. Otherwise, the GM chooses which character to move.

Some scenarios may specify which characters to move and where to move them. However, it is ultimately up to the GM's discretion to determine how characters should be moved.

Any characters repositioned by the GM are knocked off their feet, leaving them **Prone** (see page 33). Repositioning a character in this manner is not considered movement.

ABILITIES

Abilities are a key component of any encounter, and characters can use them to affect the world in a number of different ways. Each ability is comprised of the following fields, though some abilities may not include all of the fields described below. If an ability's description does not contain a certain field, the ability does not possess that field.

If an ability requires an ability check, the player responsible for the character using the ability must make a check before resolving its effects. Depending on the outcome of the check, the ability's effects may change.

Name

The ability's name.

Type

Primary, Secondary, Instant

Abilities are separated into different types, which indicate how and when they can be used.

As explained in the section on turns, *primary* abilities can be used as a primary action, and *secondary* abilities can be used as a secondary action. *Instant* abilities can be used whenever their trigger conditions are met—even on another character's turn.

Certain special abilities do not belong to any of the above types. Their descriptions will explain how and when they can be used.

Physical, Magic, Unique

Abilities are further classified as *physical*, *magic*, or *unique*. This classification affects the CR of the ability check made when the ability is used. For more information on ability checks, see page 28.

Other Classifications

Some abilities have other classifications, indicating whether the ability is *invoked*, *fire-aspected*, and so forth. This information may be referenced by character traits or other abilities.

Cost

The cost that must be paid in order to use the ability. An ability cannot be used if a character lacks the resources to pay its cost, or if expending those resources would render them incapable of using it.

Typically, abilities with a cost require their user to spend a certain amount of MP. However, some abilities draw on resources other than MP.

Abilities without a cost listed do not have one, unless otherwise detailed in their description.

Requirement

Some abilities have requirements that must be met before they can be used.

Target

The character, characters, or objects the ability affects.

- X:** The ability affects X characters chosen by the user within the ability's range. These targets may be enemies or allies, or even objects such as doors and barricades, provided the GM permits it. For the purposes of targeting, the user is considered to be an ally.
- Self:** The ability affects the user.
- Enemy/Ally:** The ability affects one or more enemies or allies. Potential targets are determined based on whether the user considers them an enemy or ally at the time the ability is used. A character could, for example, use an ability that targets an ally on a monster that was considered an enemy at the start of the encounter, but has since turned out to be an ally. For the purposes of targeting, the user is considered to be an ally.
- Special:** Abilities that do not affect characters—such as those that create or conjure something—may not have specified targets. Refer to the ability's base effect and direct hit descriptions when resolving these abilities.

Range

The distance at which the ability can be used and the number of squares it affects. Abilities do not affect targets that move out of range before its effects are resolved. For example, a target could avoid an ability by using a trait or ability of their own to flee to safety. Abilities which target their user do not have a range. The following examples illustrate common ability ranges:

- 5 squares:** The ability affects one or more targets within five squares of the user.
- A 3x3 area centered on this character:** The ability affects all targets within a 3x3 area centered on the user.
- A 3x3 area adjacent to this character:** The ability affects all targets in a 3x3 area that does not include the user but with at least one square adjacent to them.
- A 5x5 area within 10 squares of this character:** The ability affects all targets in a 5x5 area whose furthest square is no more than ten squares away from the user.

Check

The values used for ability checks (see page 28) made when using the ability.

Abilities without this field can be used without making an ability check. When a character uses the ability, simply resolve its base effect.

If an ability check is listed as "Special," refer to the ability's base effect description for more information. These abilities do not have a CR or a direct hit effect, and often require an ability check simply to see if you score a critical or if a proc effect is triggered.

CR

The challenge rating (CR) for a *physical* ability's check will always be the target's **Defense**, whereas the CR for a *magic* ability's check will always be the target's **Magic Defense**, unless otherwise stated.

Physical Ability CR = Target's Defense

Magic Ability CR = Target's Magic Defense

The CR for a *unique* ability's check can be found in the ability's description, in the scenario, or in the character's traits.

Sample Ability Ranges



A 3x3 area centered on this character



A 3x3 area adjacent to this character



A 5x5 area within 10 squares of this character

Base Effect

The effect that is resolved when the ability is used. An ability's base effect is always fully resolved, unless something interrupts or otherwise negates the use of the ability itself.

Direct Hit

An additional effect that is resolved when the character scores a direct hit with the ability.

Limitation

Indicates how many times the ability can be used in a given period of time. It may also describe other restrictions or conditions. Unless otherwise stated, abilities may not be used more times than explicitly indicated here.

Ability Checks

Many abilities require players to make an ability check when used. The check field indicates the value, often a primary attribute, to be used for this check. It will also specify the check's CR.

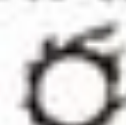
If the ability check's total equals or exceeds the CR, the ability scores a direct hit, and the effect described in its direct hit field is resolved alongside its base effect.

Some abilities have "Special" listed in their check or CR fields. In these cases, the result of an ability check or d20 roll may be referenced when resolving the ability's effect.

Rolling for Ability Effects

Abilities that deal damage or heal HP often require a dice roll to determine how potent their effects are. After making any required ability checks, roll the dice specified in the ability's base effect and, when applicable, direct hit descriptions. Use the sum of their results to calculate the amount of damage dealt or HP healed.

Criticals

If a d20 rolled for an ability check lands on a 20, then that ability is a critical. On the d20s included in the Starter Set, 20 is represented by the  icon.

Ability checks that result in a critical always score a direct hit regardless of CR, assuming the ability has a direct hit effect. Furthermore, criticals double the number of dice rolled to determine the amount of damage dealt or HP healed by the ability's effects, including any additional dice awarded by traits or abilities. All other numbers for the ability remain unchanged.

Example 1: A warrior uses their **Tomahawk** ability, which has a base effect that deals 2 points of damage plus an additional 1d6 damage on a direct hit. The player rolls a 20 on **Tomahawk**'s ability check, making it both a critical and a direct hit. Because of the critical, the player doubles the dice and rolls 2d6, then adds 2 to the sum to calculate the total damage dealt.

Example 2: A dragoon uses their **Jump** ability, which deals 2d6 + 3 damage from its base effect plus an additional 2d6 damage on a direct hit—a total of 4d6 + 3. The player rolls a 20 on **Jump**'s ability check, making it both a critical and a direct hit. Because of the critical, the player doubles the dice and rolls 8d6, then adds 3 to the sum to calculate the total damage dealt.

Ability Checks for Multiple Targets

If a character uses an ability that affects multiple targets, make a single ability check and use the resulting total to determine if the ability scores a direct hit on each target.

If the character has been granted advantage dice on ability checks against some targets but not others, roll the advantage dice for those targets separately and select which die to use when calculating the total of the check for those specific targets.

Damage and Healing for Multiple Targets

If an ability that deals damage or heals HP affects multiple targets, roll the dice once and use the resulting total to calculate the amount of damage dealt or HP healed. Each target suffers the same amount of damage or recovers the same amount of HP.

If the ability check resulted in a critical for some targets but not others, roll the additional dice once and add the results to the total from the first roll to calculate the effects for those specific targets.

Example: A black mage uses **Fire II** to target three enemies: Star Marmot A, Star Marmot B, and a little ladybug. The player makes a single ability check using their adventurer's **INT**, resulting in a total of 11. The ability check's CR is determined by the target's **Magic Defense**, which is 10 for the star marmots and 12 for the little ladybug. As such, the ability scores a direct hit on the star marmots, but not on the little ladybug.

Fire II's base effect deals 3 damage to all three targets, but because the ability scored a direct hit on the two star marmots, they also take an additional 1d6 damage. The player rolls 1d6 to determine direct hit damage, which lands on a 4. The two star marmots suffer a total of 7 damage each, while the little ladybug only suffers 3 damage from **Fire II**'s base effect.

Proc Effects

Some abilities have additional proc effects that trigger if a d20—either the one rolled for their ability check or another rolled at a time specified in their base effect description—lands on a specific number. Whether or not a proc effect is triggered is determined by the unmodified value of the die rolled.

When a proc effect is triggered, resolve the effects specified in the ability's base effect and direct hit descriptions.

ABILITY RESOLUTION

Follow these steps when using an ability:

1. **[Choose Ability]:** Select one of your character's abilities to use.
2. **[Select Target]:** If the ability requires a target or targets, select them.
3. **[Confirm Ability Check]:** If the ability requires you to make an ability check, confirm the relevant values and the check's CR, as well as whether any advantage dice or penalties apply.
4. **[Make Ability Check]:** Make the ability check using the information from step 3.
5. **[Determine Results]:** Use the total from step 4 to determine if the ability is a direct hit and if any proc effects are triggered. If you rolled a 20, the ability is a critical.
6. **[Confirm Effects]:** Confirm the ability's base effect, as well as its direct hit effect, if applicable. If the ability check resulted in a critical, the dice used to determine ability effect values are doubled. Lastly, if a proc effect was triggered, confirm its effects.
7. **[Roll Dice]:** If any part of the ability's effects require you to roll any dice, do so now.
8. **[Resolve Effects]:** Resolve the effects confirmed in step 6 for the ability's target, targets, or all targets within the ability's range. Use the results of the dice rolled in step 7 when applicable.

MARKERS

Some abilities have effects that generate markers. Markers serve as visual cues that provide advance notice of what is about to occur on the encounter map. When a marker is generated, an object or token should be placed on the encounter map to represent that marker.

Each marker is comprised of the following fields. If a field is blank, the marker does not possess that field.

Source

The ability or effect that generated the marker.

Creator

The character that used the ability that generated the marker.

If the creator is afflicted with an enfeeblement that renders them unable to maintain the marker, the marker is removed from the encounter map. Refer to the list of enfeeblements on page 33 to determine if a given enfeeblement would cause the removal of a marker.

Example 1: The party is fighting Ifrit, who uses the **Eruption** ability. The GM places a 5x5 square marker on the encounter map as specified in the ability's description. In this instance, **Eruption** is the source of the marker, and Ifrit is the marker's creator.



Ifrit uses **Eruption**, generating a marker

Example 2: To represent a collapsing ceiling inside of a crumbling mine, the GM places multiple markers on the encounter map to indicate danger areas where rocks will fall. In this case, the collapsing ceiling is the source of the markers, and there is no creator.



Rocks fall from the ceiling, generating markers

Marker Type

All markers are classified as mobile or stationary.

A mobile marker may change location or size before its effects are resolved, as long as the conditions noted in the source ability's description are met.

Stationary markers, on the other hand, are immobile and will remain in the square or squares in which they were generated until their effects are resolved.

Origin

The location in which the marker is placed on the encounter map. A marker's origin can be one or more characters or squares on the encounter map.

Marker Area

The total area that the marker will affect. This field also indicates the conditions under which a mobile marker changes location.

The GM will decide whether or not they convey to the other players how a given mobile marker moves based on instructions in the scenario or by using their own discretion.

Example: A mobile marker with a 3x3 area centered on the origin and that moves with the origin is placed on the encounter map. If the character that served as the marker's origin moves using a standard movement action, a movement effect, or is otherwise repositioned due to a special game rule, the marker moves along with the character so that the 3x3 area is always centered on them.



Target

The character, characters, or objects the marker affects.

Marker Trigger

The conditions under which the marker's effect is resolved. When these conditions are met, the marker's effect is resolved for all valid targets within the marker area.

Marker Effect

The effect that is resolved when the marker trigger's conditions are met. This field describes both the effect the marker has on its targets as well as any secondary effects the marker may have.

Unless otherwise specified, a marker's effects only apply to enemies of its creator. If a marker has no creator, it will affect all valid targets within the marker area, unless the rules specify otherwise.

MARKER RESOLUTION

Follow these steps when generating and resolving a marker:

1. **[Generate Marker]:** When an ability or effect that generates a marker is resolved, declare its source and creator.
2. **[Place Marker]:** Place an object or token on the encounter map to represent the marker to the players, and declare whether it is a mobile or stationary marker. If it is a mobile marker and you wish to share this information, declare under what conditions this marker will move.
3. **[Confirm Marker Trigger]:** Confirm the conditions under which the marker's effect is resolved.
4. **[Declare Marker Activation]:** When the marker is triggered, inform the players that the marker's effect will be resolved.
5. **[Confirm Marker Target]:** Confirm the target or targets of the marker's effects.
6. **[Confirm Marker Effect]:** Confirm the marker's effect. If this requires you to roll any dice, do so now.
7. **[Resolve Effects]:** Resolve the effect confirmed in step 6 for the marker's target, targets, or all targets within the marker's area of effect.

Sample Abilities That Generate Markers

Ability Name

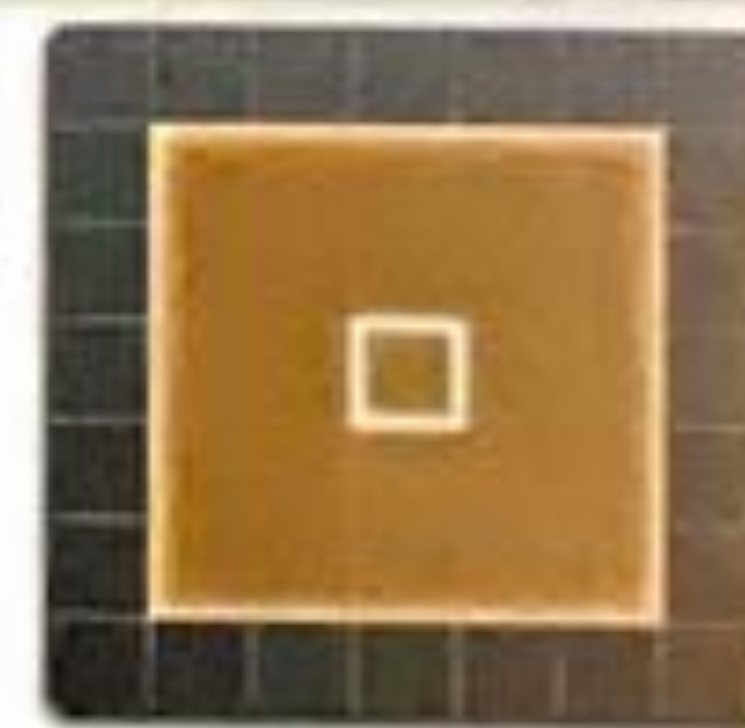
Stationary Marker

Origin: A random square containing an enemy

Marker Area: A stationary 5x5 area centered on the origin

Target: All enemies within the marker area
Marker Trigger: The beginning of this character's next turn

Marker Effect: Deals 4d6 damage to all targets



Ability Name

Mobile Marker

Origin: 1 enemy tank

Marker Area: A mobile 3x3 area centered on the origin that moves with the origin

Target: All enemies within the marker area
Marker Trigger: The beginning of this character's next turn

Marker Effect: Deals 80 damage divided evenly (rounded up) amongst all targets.



PHASES

A phase is a unit of time that helps govern an encounter. The length of a single phase can vary dramatically depending on how the encounter unfolds.

Typically, a single encounter consists of one phase. Once that phase has ended, the encounter ends along with it. However, certain special encounters—like those involving especially powerful enemies—may have multiple phases.

In such cases, a new phase will begin once the conditions outlined in the scenario are met. This might occur when all enemies have been defeated, or when a certain character's HP has been reduced to 0. New phases may see enemy reinforcements take the field, or have a unique character adopt a more powerful form. In the end, it's up to the GM to decide how to handle phases, and they are free to add, subtract, or tweak phases as they see fit.

Follow these steps when a phase ends and a new one begins:

- ◆ Remove enhancements and enfeeblements (see page 33) from all characters, unless otherwise specified.
- ◆ The GM places any additional enemies on the encounter map and adjusts enemy character information as necessary.
- ◆ Adventurers and companions with abilities that have a limited number of uses per phase have those uses restored. Turn order, HP, MP, barriers, items consumed, and benefits gained from traits such as **Umbral Mastery** and **The Beast Within** are carried over to the new phase.
- ◆ Each adventurer may immediately use one of their items.

At the start of a new phase, the encounter map may also change. In such cases, the relative position of characters will remain unchanged, so long as it does not specifically say to move them in the scenario or elsewhere.

When indicated by the scenario, characters aware that the encounter hasn't ended may be repositioned. Repositioning a character in this manner is not considered movement.

HP

HP is not a measure of a character's physical stamina, but rather a numerical representation of their physical and mental resilience and their will to survive. Characters with more HP can withstand greater damage, and those with less HP can be defeated more easily.

A character's HP can range from their **Max HP** value to 0, and cannot fall into the negative. When characters suffer damage or receive healing effects, their HP value will change. Outside of an encounter, a character's HP value will always equal their **Max HP**, unless special rules are in effect.

When a character suffers damage during an encounter, their HP value is reduced by the amount of damage taken. Damage that would cause their HP value to fall below 0 instead brings it to 0; any extra damage is ignored.

When a character receives a healing effect, their HP value is increased by the amount of HP it restores. Recovery that would cause their HP to exceed their **Max HP** value instead brings it to their **Max HP** value; any extra healing is ignored.

So long as a character's HP is not reduced to 0, losing HP has no effect on a character's abilities or attributes.

Barriers

Certain abilities can furnish characters with barriers that provide additional HP. If a character with a barrier takes damage, the damage is first subtracted from the barrier. Any damage remaining after the barrier is lost is subtracted from the character's HP. Barriers are considered separate from a character's HP, so it's possible for a barrier to allow a character to exceed their **Max HP**.

Barriers cannot be restored with healing effects, nor can two barriers be combined. If a character with a barrier gains another, the barrier with the higher HP value remains active, and the one with the lower HP value is lost. So long as the effect granting the barrier does not list a specific duration, it will last until damage eliminates it or the encounter ends.



When HP Falls to 0

When a character's HP falls to 0, that character is **Knocked Out**. A character with 0 HP cannot recover HP until the **Knocked Out** enfeeblement is removed via an ability such as **Raise**, by using an item such as a Company-Issue Tonic, or through some other special effect. When an encounter ends, characters who are **Knocked Out** regain all of their HP and are afflicted with the **Weakened** enfeeblement.

To avoid confusion, the GM may decide that when NPCs and monsters reach 0 HP, they **Die** instead of being **Knocked Out**. If an adventurer reduces a character or monster's HP to 0 but does not want to kill them, that player should declare that their adventurer has decided to inflict non-lethal damage and merely knocked their adversary out. That being said, the scenario's rules and the GM's discretion take precedence, so **Knocking Out** an enemy may not always be possible. When an enemy is **Knocked Out** or killed in an encounter, remove their token from the encounter map. When an adventurer is **Knocked Out**, however, leave their token where it is.

Refer to the enfeeblements section on page 34 for further information on what happens when a character is **Knocked Out**.

Describing Damage

As explained earlier, HP is not a representation of physical stamina. Because of this, a character with 1 HP remaining might appear whole and unharmed, and yet be just one stiff breeze from death's door. Alternatively, a character covered with countless horrible wounds may in fact be hale and hearty at **Max HP**.

But this presents a problem: how do players know whether their adversaries are brimming with life or gurgling on the verge of death? It is the rare party that doesn't want to keep tabs on their enemies' HP. Some GMs prefer to keep enemy HP counts to themselves in order to maintain immersion, while others choose to be completely transparent, revealing raw numbers to the other players.

For the GM who is looking for a creative solution to this particular problem, here are a few helpful suggestions for describing enemy HP. Feel free to use them verbatim, or as a springboard to come up with your own ideas.

When an Enemy's HP Falls below 50%

- ◆ The enemy's HP gauge has turned yellow.
- ◆ The enemy appears winded, and their movements have slowed.
- ◆ A number of cracks and dents now cover the warmachina's chassis.
- ◆ Your foe is left reeling after being struck by the bolt of fire you summoned.

When an Enemy's HP Falls below 10%

- ◆ The enemy's HP gauge is flashing red!
- ◆ Sweat drips from your foe's brow, their pained breathing clearly audible.
- ◆ Greasy smoke billows from jagged rents in the warmachina's chassis.
- ◆ It seems your foe is struggling to remain standing.

With all of that being said, remember that as a GM, there are countless ways to approach this and the other challenges you'll face, and there are no wrong answers. Feel free to experiment and find the methods that work best for you and the other players at the table.

MP

MP represents a character's reserves of mana and their ability to manipulate aether, and is often consumed as the cost of using certain abilities. An adventurer's **Max MP** is 5. NPCs and monsters do not use MP unless specifically stated.

An adventurer's MP can range from their **Max MP** value to 0, and cannot fall into the negative. When adventurers expend or recover MP, their MP value will change accordingly. Outside of an encounter, a character's MP value will always equal their **Max MP**, unless special rules are in effect.

When an adventurer uses an ability that costs MP, their MP value is reduced by the amount specified in the ability's description. A reduction in MP does not affect a character's abilities or attributes, and they can act normally even if their MP drops to 0. They simply will be unable to use abilities that cost MP.

Natural MP Recovery

While in an encounter, all adventurers will automatically recover 2 MP at the end of a round's [Adventurer Step], before the [Enemy Step] begins.

Some abilities and traits have effects that alter the amount of MP a character recovers at the end of the [Adventurer Step]. Be sure to take any such effects into account when recovering MP.

LIMIT BREAKS

Limit breaks are special abilities that can be used in encounters of great importance or when fighting powerful enemies.

Whether or not limit breaks are available for use depends on the scenario and the GM's discretion. The GM will inform players at the start of the turn, round, or phase in which they become available.

A party of adventurers can use up to three limit breaks per encounter. However, an adventurer who has used a limit break once in an encounter cannot do so again during that same encounter.

Limit breaks have triggers listed in their descriptions and can be used when those conditions are met, even if it is not the adventurer's turn. They are not classified as *instant* abilities, and as such can be used even if the adventurer has already used an *instant* ability that turn.

Limit breaks whose trigger is listed as **Any time** can also be used to interrupt the resolution of another ability or a marker's effect. For example, say a powerful enemy targets a wounded ally with an ability. After the dice roll to determine the amount of damage its effect inflicts but before the ability's effect is resolved, a white mage uses their limit break, **Pulse of Life**. This limit break heals the targeted ally, giving them enough HP to weather their enemy's fearsome blow.

ENHANCEMENTS

Any condition that has a beneficial effect on a character is considered an enhancement. Enhancements wear off in the manner specified in their effect description, after a period of time elapses, or at the end of a phase.

Unless otherwise specified, a given character cannot use the same ability or trait to grant multiple instances of an enhancement to a single target. When a new instance of an enhancement is applied by the same character, it overwrites the original instance. However, multiple characters can apply separate instances of an enhancement to a single target using the same ability or trait.

At times, the scenario may specify that one or more characters are granted an enhancement. These enhancements will be defined in the descriptions of the effects that granted them.



ENFEEBLEMENTS

Any condition that has a detrimental effect on a character is considered an enfeeblement. Enfeeblements wear off in the manner specified in their effect description, after a period of time elapses, when abilities or items are used to remove them, or at the end of a phase.

Unless otherwise specified, a given character cannot use the same ability or trait to inflict multiple instances of an enfeeblement to a single target. When a new instance of an enfeeblement is applied by the same character, it overwrites the original instance. However, multiple characters can apply separate instances of an enfeeblement to a single target using the same ability or trait.

At times, the scenario may specify that one or more characters are afflicted with an enfeeblement. These enfeeblements will be defined in the descriptions of the effects that inflicted them.

The list below includes the most common enfeeblements:

Damage Over Time (DOT)

- Damage over time effects always specify the amount of damage they inflict using a set of parentheses, such as **DOT (3)** or **DOT (User's INT)**.
- An adventurer or ally afflicted with a damage over time effect takes damage specified by the **DOT** at the end of each round's [Adventurer Step].
- An enemy afflicted with a damage over time effect takes damage specified by the **DOT** at the end of each round's [Enemy Step].

Prone

- A **Prone** character cannot take a standard movement action on their turn unless they spend half their **Speed** (rounded up, typically 3 squares) to get back on their feet. Standing up in this fashion removes the **Prone** enfeeblement.
- A **Prone** character incurs a -2 penalty on all checks.
- Characters receive one advantage die when making ability checks targeting a **Prone** character.
- The **Prone** enfeeblement does not stack, even if it is inflicted multiple times. In these cases, only a single instance of the effect remains.

Slow

- A **Slowed** character has their **Speed** halved (rounded up) and cannot be affected by effects which would add to their **Speed**.
- A **Slowed** character incurs a -2 penalty on all checks.

Blind

- A **Blinded** character cannot see and automatically fails checks that rely entirely on vision. Ability checks made when using abilities that target enemies or allies incur the penalty listed below, as **Blinded** characters can still rely on their other senses to get a general idea of the target's position.
- Characters receive one advantage die when making ability checks targeting a **Blinded** character.
- A **Blinded** character incurs a -2 penalty on all checks.

Stun

- A **Stunned** character cannot act during their turn or use *instant* abilities.
- Any and all markers for which a **Stunned** character is the creator are removed.
- Characters receive one advantage die when making ability checks targeting a **Stunned** character.
- A **Stunned** character incurs a -5 penalty on all checks.
- The **Stunned** enfeeblement can only be removed via the means detailed in the description of the effect that inflicted it. It cannot be removed by effects that remove enfeeblements.

Knocked Out

- A character that has been **Knocked Out** is unconscious and cannot perceive their surroundings. They cannot use abilities or perform other actions during their turn.
- A character that has been **Knocked Out** is treated as both **Prone** and **Stunned**.
- A character that has been **Knocked Out** cannot recover HP or MP.
- The **Knocked Out** enfeeblement does not wear off at the end of a phase, and can only be removed by effects that specifically remove it.
- A **Knocked Out** character has all enhancements and enfeeblements removed and can be afflicted with no further enfeeblements except the **Comatose** enfeeblement.

Weakness

- A **Weakened** character incurs a -2 penalty on all checks.
- If a character afflicted with **Weakness** is the target of another effect that inflicts this enfeeblement, they are instead afflicted with the **Brink of Death** enfeeblement.
- The **Weakened** enfeeblement does not wear off at the end of a phase, and can only be removed by completing a rest action (see page 17 of the Gamemaster Book) or by effects that specifically remove it.

Brink of Death

- A character on the **Brink of Death** incurs a -5 penalty on all checks.
- If a character on the **Brink of Death** is the target of another effect that inflicts this enfeeblement, they are instead afflicted with the **Comatose** enfeeblement.
- The **Brink of Death** enfeeblement does not wear off at the end of a phase, and can only be removed by completing a rest action (see page 17 of the Gamemaster Book) or by effects that specifically remove it.

Comatose

- A **Comatose** character is treated as if they were **Knocked Out** for gameplay purposes.
- The **Comatose** enfeeblement can only be removed by spending one sun—a full day in-game—in a location where appropriate medical treatment is available, as determined by the GM.
- A **Comatose** character has all enhancements and enfeeblements removed and can receive no further enfeeblements except **Death**.

Death

- As the name implies, a **Dead** character has died and can no longer participate in the game.
- Unless otherwise specified, **Death** cannot be reversed or removed.

Note that characters who have been **Knocked Out** or are **Comatose** will not **Die**, unless the scenario or the GM rules otherwise.



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RULE SUMMARY

CHECKS

When a character takes an action where the outcome is uncertain, the player controlling that character makes a check to determine success or failure.

To make a check, roll a d20 and add the appropriate **value**—usually a primary attribute. If this **total** equals or exceeds the check's **CR**, your character succeeds. If the **total** is lower than the check's **CR**, their attempt ends in failure.

Before making a check, the GM will determine the type of check required and assign it a **CR**.

$$\text{d20} + \text{Value} = \text{Total}$$

Total $\geq$ CR $\Rightarrow$ Success

Total < CR $\Rightarrow$ Failure

ADVANTAGE DICE AND PENALTIES

Some traits, abilities, enhancements, enfeeblements, and situations will grant you advantage dice or impose penalties when making certain checks.

Making Checks with Advantage Dice

Roll one extra d20 for each advantage die, then choose which result to use for the check. For example, if you have one advantage die when making a check, roll a total of two d20s, then choose which of the results to use.

Making Checks with Penalties

Subtract the largest applicable penalty from the total for the check.

ENCOUNTER BASICS

Encounters play out over a series of rounds. Each round, all characters participating in the encounter take a single turn, beginning with the adventurers and their allies.

ENCOUNTER OVERVIEW

Starting an Encounter

- 1 **Surprise:** The GM determines whether any of the characters participating in the encounter have been caught by surprise.
- 2 **Positioning:** The GM determines the positions of all enemies participating in the encounter. Players do the same for their adventurers.
- 3 **Turn Order:** Players determine the order in which their adventurers and allies take their turns.

Round Overview

- 1 **[Adventurer Step]:** Each adventurer and allied character participating in the encounter takes a turn, following the turn order.
- 2 **[Enemy Step]:** Each enemy participating in the encounter takes a turn.
- 3 **[End of Round Step]:** The current round ends, a new round begins, and the order of play starts over at the **[Adventurer Step]**.

ADVENTURER TURNS

Each turn, an adventurer can perform one of each of the following:

A Primary Action

A Secondary Action

Standard Movement or Focus

- **Primary Action:** Use a *primary* or *secondary* ability.
- **Secondary Action:** Use a *secondary* ability.
- **Standard Movement:** Move a number of squares on the map up to your character's **Speed**.
Example: An adventurer with a **Speed** of five squares could move two squares, perform a primary action, move one square, perform a secondary action, then use the last two squares of their standard movement to move again before ending their turn.
- **Focus:** Forgo all standard movement to perform an additional secondary action, for a total of two secondary actions in a single turn.

Instant Abilities: *Instant* abilities may be used during any character's turn, provided their trigger conditions are met. However, a character cannot use multiple *instant* abilities on a given turn.

PHASES

Some encounters consist of multiple phases. The start of a new phase may see enemy reinforcements take the field, or have a powerful foe adopt a new form.

When a phase ends and a new one begins, remove enhancements and enfeeblements from all characters. Adventurers with abilities that have limited uses per phase have those uses restored.

Turn order, HP, MP, barriers, items consumed, and benefits gained from traits are carried over to the new phase.

ABILITY CHECKS

Many abilities require players to make an ability check when used during an encounter. These ability checks can have many purposes, but they are primarily used to determine if an ability scores a direct hit.

- **When using an ability with a check field,** make an ability check using the indicated value. The ability check's CR will be listed in the CR field, and is typically the target's **Defense** or **Magic Defense**.
If the ability check's total is lower than the CR, simply resolve the ability's base effect. If this total equals or exceeds the CR, resolve the effect described in its direct hit field as well.
- **When using an ability without a check field,** simply resolve its base effect without making an ability check.
- **Criticals:** If the d20 rolled for an ability check lands on a 20, that ability is a critical. Criticals double the number of dice rolled to determine the amount of damage dealt or HP healed by the ability's effects.
- **Abilities with Multiple Targets:** When using an ability that affects multiple targets, make a single ability check and use the resulting total to determine if the ability scores a direct hit on each target. If the ability deals damage or restores HP to multiple targets, roll the dice once. Each target suffers the same amount of damage or recovers the same amount of HP.
If you have been granted advantage dice on ability checks against some targets but not others, roll the advantage dice for those targets separately.

LIMIT BREAKS

During an encounter, the GM will inform players if and when limit breaks become available, after which the party can use up to three limit breaks. However, each adventurer can only use one limit break per encounter.